PRE-COLONIAL THEATRE

Ritual, Mask and Festival: The Grammar of African Performance

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The elements that make African festival performance work - space, time, mask, music, participation - and how a modern production can use them honestly.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- sacred space
- time
- mask
- music
- participation

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Space is made, not found

A festival space is not a building; it is a place made special by performance: the market square, the shrine, the compound, the street. The boundary between performers and audience is porous and often crossed. A circle is the commonest form, because a circle lets everyone see and lets the audience become part of the event.

When a modern director stages a festival play in a proscenium, the first decision is how to recover that circle: a thrust, a traverse, an apron, or an audience on three sides.

Time is not uniform

Festival time is not clock time. It begins when the drum begins and ends when the last mask leaves; it can stretch, repeat and return. This is why festival-derived plays often refuse the tight three-act clock of the European stage and move in episodes, processions and returns.

Soyinka's idea of the "fourth stage" - the transitional gulf between the worlds of the living, the dead and the unborn - is the best-known attempt to describe this time in critical language.

The mask does three things

It conceals the wearer, it presents a character, and it transforms the wearer into something else. Each function changes the actor's work: a concealed actor can play a god; a presented character can be judged; a transformed performer is no longer an actor at all, and the audience knows it.

Modern productions that use masks should decide which of the three they want. A mask used as decoration gets laughter; a mask used as transformation gets silence.

Music and participation

The drum is the spine of the form: it calls, answers, cues entrances and tells the audience what is happening. Songs carry the text the audience already knows and invite them to join. The audience's response - a shout, a comment, a dance step - is part of the performance, not an interruption.

A director who wants this energy must rehearse the audience's participation: leave the space, time the call, teach the response. Participation is not chaos; it is choreography.

Taking festival form indoors

A festival form moved into a hall loses three things immediately: the sky, the crowd and the duration. The designer's job is to restore equivalents. A cyclorama or a dark surround can stand for the sky; a thrust or an apron can put the audience where the crowd was; an episodic structure can restore the sense of time passing rather than being cut to ninety minutes.

Do not reproduce a shrine on a proscenium and call it ritual. The honest move is to find the performance principle - procession, possession, contest, departure - and stage that. The audience will feel the form even when the setting is a hall.

Work with practitioners. If the production uses a masquerade, a drummer or a praise-singer, they are collaborators with authority over their material, not hired effects. Agree the terms in writing, credit them properly, and let them

correct you.

Documentation as a discipline

If you are studying a festival you can attend, prepare before you go: a permissions letter, a recording plan, a shot list of what you need (space, costume, instruments, audience), and questions for the organisers. A performance that lasts six hours will not wait for you to decide what to photograph.

Record the frame, not just the highlight: the procession, the waiting, the drummers, the vendors, the children, the end. Theatre scholarship has been damaged by photographs of the mask and nothing else.

Exercises

1. Stage a five-minute ritual sequence in the round, with a drum, a mask and an audience that is invited to respond.
2. Diagram the space and the time of a festival you know, and mark where the audience crosses the boundary.
3. Design a mask for a character in a modern play and write down which of the three functions it serves.

Where to read more

Wole Soyinka, Myth, Literature and the African World (1976)

Henry John Drewal and Margaret Thompson Drewal, Gelede (1983)

Joachim Fiebach, The Hidden Work (1996)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.